

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

1 Peter

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First Peter has one main purpose: to encourage Christians to stay faithful while they suffer for their faith. Peter wrote to believers who were facing “the fiery trial” or severe testing. The people around them rejected their faith, criticized their way of life, and mocked their hope in Christ. Peter calls his readers to respond by living in the grace of God. They should do this to please God and to show others what he is like.

Setting

Many people in the ancient Roman world thought Christians were strange, superstitious, and not loyal to Roman society. Christians met in private. They also practiced rituals that many people did not understand, such as the Lord’s Supper. Some people wrongly thought this meal involved a bloody sacrifice.

Christians also lived in a way that was different from the culture around them. Some refused to serve in the Roman army because they would not swear loyalty to the emperor as a god. Because they would not follow common Roman practices, Christians were often treated unfairly. People accused them of wrongdoing and sometimes brought them to court on false charges.

First Peter speaks to this situation. Believers were suffering through very hard trials (1 Peter 1:6; 4:12). Other people were saying evil things about them (4:4; see 3:16). Christ’s followers may have wanted to answer harsh words with more harsh words. They may also have felt tempted to stop living in a godly way because it brought them pain.

The apostle knew about these temptations. So his letter encourages believers to see false charges and unfair treatment as a chance to speak about Jesus Christ.

Christians should follow the example of their Lord. Jesus lived a good and faithful life before everyone. He did not insult those who insulted him. In the same way, Christians can show the good news about Jesus through the way they live.

Summary

After the usual opening of a letter (1 Peter 1:1–2), Peter begins the first section (1 Peter 1:3–2:12) by encouraging his readers. Their suffering is painful, but it is

temporary. God can use it to strengthen their faith and prepare them to receive salvation (1:3–9).

This salvation is very great. The prophets spoke about it before it came, and angels desire to understand it (1:10–12). Because God gave this gift, believers should live holy lives. They should remember the great cost God paid to save them (1:13–21).

The first section ends with a call to love other Christians and be patient with them (1:22–2:3). Peter also reminds believers that they are God’s new covenant people (2:4–12).

The second part of the letter (1 Peter 2:13–3:12) urges Christians to respect accepted authorities. Their actions can show faithfulness to God in a world that is against them.

Christians should accept the authority of the government (2:13–17). Christian slaves should accept the authority of their masters (2:18–25). Christian wives should accept the authority of their husbands (3:1–6). At the same time, husbands should honor their wives (3:7).

This section ends with general instructions about the kind of behavior that God rewards (3:8–12).

The third section (1 Peter 3:13–4:11) begins by urging believers to respond to social pressure with honorable and respectful behavior, even when others treat them badly (3:13–17).

Peter reminds his readers that their hope of redemption (God rescuing them from sin and death) is secure. This hope rests on Christ’s life, death, resurrection, and ascension (his return to heaven; see 3:18–22).

Peter again calls believers to reject the ways and values of the world (4:1–6). He ends the section with several instructions about how Christians should live (4:7–11).

The fourth section of the letter (1 Peter 4:12–5:11) begins with a final call to stand firm during suffering (4:12–19).

Peter then gives instructions to elders (5:1–4), younger men (5:5), and the whole church (5:5–11).

The letter ends with the usual greetings (5:12–14).

Author and Recipients

The opening verse names the author as the apostle Peter. It also names the readers as “the elect” (God’s chosen people) who lived in “Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia.” These Roman provinces

were in the northern part of Asia Minor. Today, this peninsula makes up most of Turkey.

We have no record that Peter visited this area. The letter also does not say that he visited it. In fact, we know little about where Peter went or what he did after his early ministry in Jerusalem and Judea (Acts 1:1–12:25).

Luke says that after God rescued Peter from prison in a miraculous way, Peter “left for another place” (Acts 12:17). Many people have guessed where he went, but we do not know.

Peter returned for the council in Jerusalem (Acts 15:1–41). . This council took place around AD 49–50. Peter also seems to have spent some time serving in Corinth (see 1 Corinthians 1:12; 9:5). He was also in Antioch at some point (Galatians 2:11–16).

Christian tradition says that Peter was in Rome near the end of his life. It also says that he died there as a martyr, a person killed because of faithfulness to Christ. This likely happened under the emperor Nero, probably in AD 64 or 65.

Place and Date of Writing

Peter was probably in Rome when he wrote this letter. The phrase “The church in Babylon” most likely refers to the church in Rome (5:13). The ancient city of Babylon is well known from later Old Testament books. But in Peter’s time, the first century AD, Babylon was small and not politically important. It would also be surprising if Peter had traveled so far east.

However, Babylon had been a powerful city in the 600s and 500s BC. Because of this, its name came to stand for a center of world power and cultural influence. The book of Revelation uses Babylon as a code word for Rome (see Revelation 17:5). Peter was probably using the name in the same way.

If Peter wrote this letter from Rome, then he probably wrote it near the end of his life. Mark was also with Peter at this time (see 1 Peter 5:13), which supports this view. Christian tradition says that Mark was with Peter in Rome in the late AD 50s and early AD 60s.

So Peter likely wrote this letter from Rome in the early AD 60s.

Occasion of Writing

Peter wrote his letter because Christians in northern Asia Minor were facing severe trials. Some people have tried to connect 1 Peter to a known official persecution. But the letter does not say that the Roman

government was carrying out an official program of persecution against Christians.

Instead, most pressure came from the local people. At times, local officials may have helped or supported this mistreatment.

Meaning and Message

First Peter encourages Christians to live holy lives, even when they face pressure from people who do not follow Christ or who are against Christians.

Peter develops three main ideas:

1. Believers need to understand what God has done for them. They have received the salvation that God promised through his prophets. This salvation is something even the angels are eagerly watching (1:12; see 1:5, 10).

Believers are God’s children (1:14). They have been born again through God’s powerful word (1:23). They are like stones that God is using to build a new spiritual temple, a place where God is worshiped (2:5). They are also a chosen people whom God has called out of darkness and into light (2:9–10).

Because believers have received these gifts, they are now like foreigners and strangers in this world (1:1, 17; 2:12). Christians live in the world, but they do not belong to the world.

1. Christians are God’s people. So they should live in a way that shows the values of heaven, not the values of this world. As God’s children, Christians should follow the example of their Father. They should become holy, because God is holy (1:15–16).

Christians should also love one another (1:22). and respect those in authority. Peter summarizes this by calling Christians to “to do good.” They should do good even to people who mistreat them and make life difficult for them (3:16–17; 4:19).

1. Believers have become a holy people because of Christ. The death and resurrection of Jesus are the foundation of their new identity (1:18–19; 3:18). His victory over evil powers gives them hope and confidence (1:3–9; 3:19–22).

Christ made salvation and holiness possible for them. He also gave them an example to follow. Christ did not fight back when people criticized him, persecuted him, and even killed him (2:21–25). Christians should follow his example. They should not seek revenge. Instead, they should use their trials as a chance to speak about the grace and power of God.